And then, as soon as I sat down, I remembered something. *Why didn't I thank the most important person of all? Why didn't I thank Victoria?*

I'd missed the moment: Jorge Valdano was standing facing us. He started speaking, in Spanish of course. At first, José was translating but, as people got swept up in the speech, they started throwing in their own suggestions for what particular words might mean in English. It got a little confusing, but Senor Valdano knew where he was going and ploughed on regardless:

'Three years ago, Florentino Perez ran for the Presidency of Real Madrid. People thought of him as a cold, rational businessman and wondered if he was the right man for the job. He won the election eventually because he did the most passionate, hot-headed, impossible thing that any supporter could imagine: he bought Luis Figo from Barcelona. Senor Perez came to the Presidency with the ambition to make the soccer club, recognized by FIFA as the most renowned of the 20th century, the greatest in the 21st. To do this we needed the right players: the best players but also the players who represented soccer—and Real Madrid—in the best way. Raul was already here. A year after Figo, the President brought Zidane to the Bernabeu. A year after him, Ronaldo. Still, there was an element missing. We believe that you, David, are the player Real Madrid need to be complete. Because of your ability but also because you can bring with you a soccer spirit which is epitomized by the captain of England.'

You could tell from Senor Valdano's tone of voice and his body language, even without understanding the Spanish, that he was building up to a big finish. He took a deep breath. And José's cell phone went off: one of those phones that diverts all your calls except the one you really have to answer.

'El Presidente.'

There was a lot of laughing and joking between José and Senor Perez.

'David, the President wants to tell you he's very sorry he can't be here with us tonight but he's never done this with any of our other big signings. So he doesn't think it would be the right thing to do this time either.'

A pause. Just to make sure we got the joke.

'He says: not that you aren't his favorite, of course.'

Everybody in the room was laughing now, and shouting into José's phone that the President should just come round for a coffee.